

headquarters—sometimes even as my bedroom. I transacted enormous amounts of business and signed many important leases, contracts and agreements in the front seat of the mud-splattered tin lizzy.

When it was necessary to have documents witnessed, one or two of my drillers or roustabouts scrawled their signatures on the papers, using the jalopy's wrinkled

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fenders as writing surfaces. There wasn't anything unusual about any of this. Almost every independent operator—the wildcatter—who prospected and drilled for oil during the early days in Oklahoma operated in much the same manner. He had no fixed hours, no five-day week. He had to be his own promoter, geologist, legal advisor, explosives expert, drilling superintendent and jack-of-all-trades. Most of his time was spent in the field, working alongside his men.

He often went for days without any sleep save for what naps he could take on the drilling rig or curled up in his automobile.

The wildcatter operated on a perpetually frayed shoe-string budget—at least until he brought in his first big producer. He constantly faced heavy competition; his business was fraught with innumerable financial perils and pitfalls; as a natural consequence, he developed certain traits and techniques and learned certain lessons which, I'm afraid, today's young businessmen have little opportunity to develop or learn.

We, the "independents," eliminated all unnecessary administrative overhead expenses in our operations. We scorned renting offices in the boom towns that burgeoned around the oil fields, partly because we didn't want to spend the extra money on what we considered an unnecessary frill, but mainly because we knew that it was impossible to run our operations properly from behind a desk. We familiarized ourselves thoroughly with all aspects of our business and kept all our costs down by exercising unceasing and vigilant supervision over every phase of our operations. We often worked employee-morale and production miracles by donning overalls and sweating and